the ground to be able to perform 100 per cent in air. And remember, you must always think ahead of your aircraft.'

Once this was done, the cadets would report to their respective instructors to tell them that they were ready for the sortie. The instructor would then quiz the cadets to check how prepared they were for it. Once satisfied, the instructor and the cadet would go to the daily servicing section, where the technical staff would make the instructor sign an aircraft maintenance form, Form 700, containing the entire technical and service history of the aircraft, after all the necessary technical checks were carried out.

What followed was one of my favourite things during the entire training. The pupil and the instructor would walk to the aircraft together. It would be a meticulously disciplined walk, where the instructor would walk on the right and the pupil on the left, a step behind the instructor. Together, they would walk in step towards the aircraft, their helmets in their left hands, resting against the waist. A sense of pride filled my heart every time I did it. Even to this day, it makes my hair stand on end when I think about it.

Certain external visual checks to ensure that the covers were on or the chokes in place would be carried out while approaching the aircraft. Both the instructor and the pupil would then place their helmets on one of the wings and go around the aircraft, carefully performing mandatory checks as per the checklist. The checklist was meant to be learnt by heart, and included a plethora of procedures before start-up, after start-up and even when airborne.

I remember the first time I entered the aircraft with my instructor—a sense of achievement and pride engulfed my heart and mind. I imagined Papaji standing at the edge of the tarmac, looking at me with a broad smile. I imagined Dada shouting loudly, 'Way to go, Gunju!' I imagined Maa standing next to Papaji, telling him how proud she was to see me preparing for take-off. I desperately wished for my entire family to be there to see me fly for the first time. But I was still happy knowing that I had achieved what I had set out to, and it was only a matter of time until I earned the ranks. I was happy that Papaji would soon brag about his daughter to his course